

Saturday May 8th & Sunday May 9th, 2010
Onion Valley, CA

Saturday Sierra Club Leader Snow Training

May is still a bit early in the season for Sierra trips with many trailheads still inaccessible due to snow particularly in year like this where we have an above average snow deposit. Granted, that's not a problem if your whole purpose is to get out on the snow.

Unless this happens:



Nice to see my bad weather luck survived the off season!

Saturday was a class partially sponsored by the Sierra Club with the goal expanding the pool of leader experience by learning some outside techniques. I'm always up for more training so of course I signed up.

As usual I flew back in to the Orange County airport and after a few hours of panicked preparation had all my gear and was driving up to the Sierra by 8-ish pm. This time I actually had Jason Stone to carpool with which was a nice change of pace.

We arrived in Lone Pine sometime after midnight and set up camp in the nearby Alabama Hills BLM land. I didn't bother with a tent instead just throwing out a sleeping pad and climbing into my sleeping bag.

It was a beautiful night



After waking up a bit before dawn and making my usual wake-the-dead strength camp coffee we were off to Independence 20 minutes to the north.



The meeting point of the trip was the house of Sierra Club leader extraordinaire Tina Bowman to fill out all of our paperwork and meet the instructor for the day, two time Everest summitter Kurt Wedburg.



After a brief speech rental equipment was distributed and we were we off to the trailhead.



The class was held out of Onion Valley which is just up the road from Independence.





Initially we learned a few new rope techniques such as the kiwi coil and went over a the knots we would be using throughout the day. After the prep for my Sierra club rock check off and SCMA I've practiced climbing knots to an all but absurd degree and so face the opportunity to learn a new way to do a

particular knot with an annoying amount of glee.



My hat stands out a bit.

After the initial fun was done we walked up to a snow slope and started the real instruction. Most of it was more along the lines of guide tricks as opposed to anything we'd use as Sierra Club leaders but it's still nice to have extra skills in your bag.



What I'm doing here basically allows me to catch the participants in the event they slip.



We also got to do some roped up travel practice which is something I'd like to get more experience with.





And that would be lenticular clouds in a classic Sierra wave formation. Basically warns you weather is on the way. We already knew this though we were under the impression it would hit Monday. Silly us.

After a full day most folks headed for home but a few of us met at the usual Whitney Café and had dinner and discussed the plans for the next day. We convinced another couple from the class, Greg and Lisa, to tag along for the planned Sunday adventure. They were WTC students from the current year and didn't know what they were in for ☺

Jason and I headed out to camp in Alabama Hills for another night this time joined by Joe Spiegel, another Sierra club Leader and recruit for the next day.

Sunday! Sunday! Sunda-Oh *crap*, is that a storm?!



It was another beautiful night sleeping under the stars. I wouldn't even have bothered with my bivy sack if it wasn't for the large amount of inquisitive ants and stink beetles that kept trying to make friends.

The next morning Jason, Joe, and I met Greg & Lisa at the Onion Valley trailhead and set off amid sunshine and clear skies up the drainage leading to Robinson Lake. It was again windy and cool but we were plenty warm once we got moving.



The first few hours were an easy slog up from Onion Valley to a bowl at the end of Robinson Lake drainage.



Eventually we were far enough back to get a look at the Sierra Crest and get the real in-the-mountains feel.



I actually thought Greg & Lisa were kidding when they said something about eating a cheeseburger. They promptly showed me by pulling out their McDonalds bags and munching down on cold cheeseburgers. *gak*



Once the dry heaves were done with the real fun began. We picked a snow chute we were (fairly) confident would get us where we needed to go and started up.



And up...



And then we really started going up.



The general technique on steep snow is to face in, slam the shaft of the ice axe down in the snow, hold on with both hands, then kick steps with your feet.



We had about a 1200 ft climb of the chute and after the burgers at the bottom one of our group wasn't feeling overly well.



After making it about $\frac{3}{4}$ of the way up the chute Jason looked at the weather and decided if he was going to get any use out of his split board now was the time. He bid us all farewell, traded his crampons for his board, and took off down the chute.

Somewhere along the way the wisps of clouds had solidified and started dropping snow on us.



After an extended period of rather steep kick stepping we made it to the top of the chute and had a chance to rest on a small area of exposed rock at 13,200 ft. It was *cold*.



First order of business was to pull on every scrap of clothing we had with us.

At that point the weather took a strong turn towards the worse. There was a clear use trail heading through the rocks to the other side of the ridge but when Joe stuck his head around the corner it was bad news. I went and was promptly hit by winds so cold and hard they sucked the warmth out the seams of my mountaineering gloves leaving my hands cold and stiff. Ouch.

Clouds had rolled in and the snow was falling in increasing amounts.

Lisa and Greg soon joined us on the balcony but it was clear we couldn't continue. We did get about a 10 second look at what we believed to be the peak when the clouds broke.



It was too far away considering the high winds we were being hit with. Also the snow field you can see ended in a rather fatal looking drop. We made the call to turn around just a few hundred feet from the summit.



The descent was a lot like the climb and a surprising amount of work, especially hard on the back. The amount of snow being dropped on us was increasing and the wind had started to pick up.



We had hoped to glissade (butt slide with the axe as a rudder/speed control) but that turned out to be impossible due to the fact the snow was hard and icy. In the interest of safety we chose to walk the all the way down.



Even once we were down the chute we had several miles to descend before we reached the cars. While this would have been a fairly fast trip if we were able to glissade the steep sections that was impossible due to the state of the snow and the fact we couldn't see more than 10 ft in front of us at times.

See the video below for what it was like:

<http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/4596963629/in/set-72157624036790404/>



I was bringing up the rear keeping an eye on everyone but even with only 4 people I was losing sight of Joe in the front from time to time.

We made it out around 5:30 as it was starting to get dark.



We found Jason back at the cars. After he left us most of the way up the chute we was able to ski down to the cars by 2 pm and miss the worst of the weather. Poor guy.



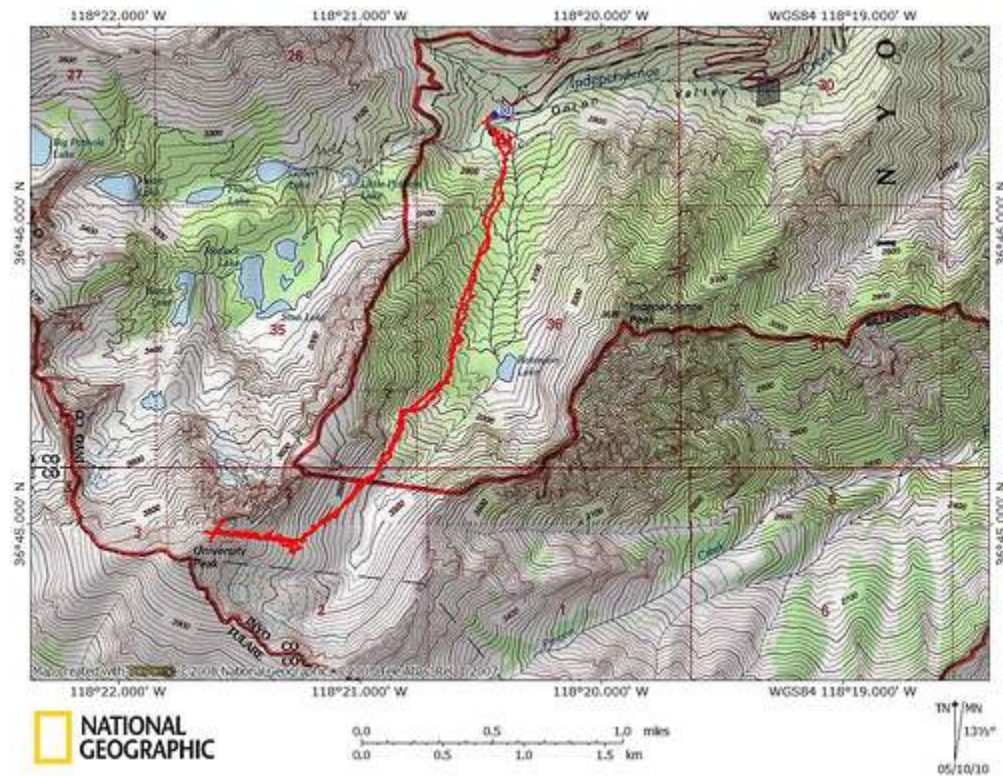
The drive down to Independence from Onion Valley was an adventure in and of itself as we could hardly see past the front of Jason's truck at times.



Everyone made it down safe and we reconvened at the Independence Subway which gave us a clear view back towards the peaks where the storm was hitting full force.



Driving home south on 395 we hit fierce winds. Most of the truckers were pulled to the side just trying to wait out the storm.



I ended up making it back to my apartment sometime before 1 am with pretty much all of my gear in disarray and soaking wet from the snow that had managed to penetrate even the smallest opening in my pack. As usual it was a very early 4 am wakeup call to go catch a plane back to Boise.

Next weekend I'll be joining a trip to Smith & Crag in the southern Sierra. Bear central!